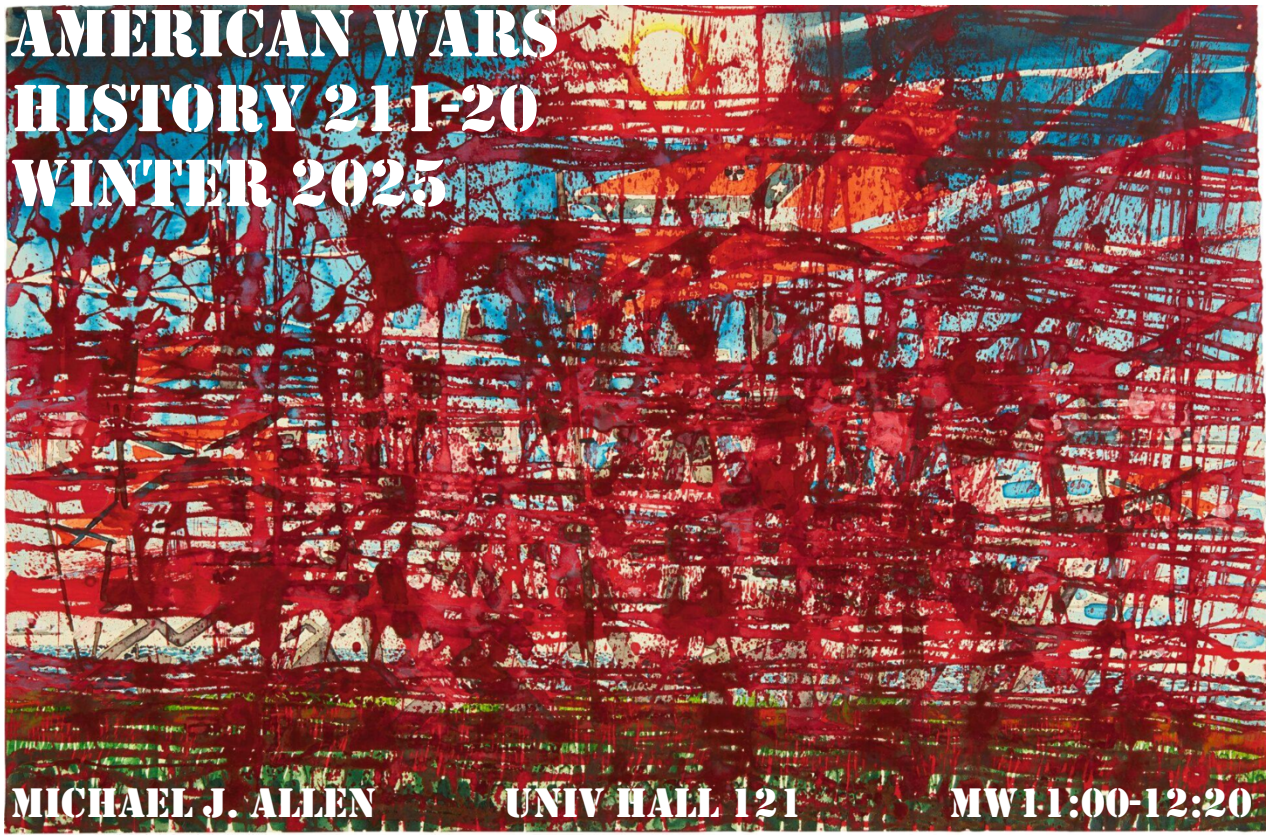

Course Description: The history of the United States is a history of war. The United States emerged through wars with and against indigenous peoples and European empires. It expanded through wars of conquest and survived Civil War. War stamped its politics, forged its social order and institutions, fueled its economy, and defined its borders. The nation has been at war almost constantly since 1898 with untold consequences for Americans, their allies and enemies, and a world caught in the crossfire.

Yet as with all things so ubiquitous, war has often gone unnoticed. Like our own shadow, it is always with us yet seldom seen; like the sun, it can be painful to look at directly for too long. Once up close and visceral, American wars grew more remote and ill-defined over time. This was especially true on elite college campuses like ours, which have not sent large numbers of students, faculty, or alumni to war since 1945 even as military spending, veteran benefits, and conscription policies have dramatically reshaped higher education in the decades since. As military veterans passed from the scene, military history passed from college curriculums and consciousness, leaving growing numbers of college students with little real awareness of this defining feature of the American past and present.

This course aims to change that. Combining broad chronological coverage with topical concerns about race, sex, gender, citizenship, law, and political economy, it views the US and its place in the world through the prism of war with an emphasis on society and culture, not military operations. With so much ground to cover, it necessarily moves quickly, seeking patterns and themes not in-depth analysis. As it goes it educates students in college-level historical reading, thinking, writing, and verbal expression. Readings consist of primary sources and scholarly articles. Assessment is based on class participation, weekly quizzes, two in-class exams, and regular analytic writing. No prerequisites or prior knowledge is required, all students are welcome.

Learning Objectives (FD-HS):
In this course students will:

- Read, analyze, and evaluate varied primary source materials to become familiar with how diverse groups experienced and participated in American wars and to learn to make sense of variation and disagreement within such source materials, which form the basis of historical inquiry, argument, and empirical proof.
- Read, analyze, and evaluate varied secondary sources that offer scholarly interpretations of key questions in the history of American warfare, thereby developing proficiency in historical argument, documentation, and debate.
- Engage in reasoned, respectful, evidence-based discussion and debate with other interpreters of history in verbal and written forms.
- Analyze, synthesize, and organize varied source materials into accurate and persuasive verbal and written arguments in answer to historical questions.
- Gain foundational knowledge of the political, social, cultural, intellectual, and technological forces implicated in American war-making and learn how they interacted across time and space to shape American and world history.

US Overlay Learning Objectives (US Perspectives on Power, Justice, and Equity):
In this course students will:

- Consider how differences of race, ethnicity, religion, region, gender, sexuality, class, nation, and political organization shaped and were shaped by armed conflict involving Americans and their government.
- Explore how practices, conditions, and ideologies of slavery, settler colonialism, nationalism, and white supremacy motivated, influenced, undermined, or reinforced American war making, while also considering how such forces were contested and changed through war and conflict.
- Consider ways in which Americans wars gave reinforced, restructured, and revolutionized structures of power, oppression, and hierarchy in the United States and around the world while exploring ways in which political and social movements organized in response to such changes, sometimes by joining, harnessing, and directing war's energies, sometimes by standing in opposition to war.
- Analyze the ways in which war is a complex, dynamic process of creative destruction with attention to the many different ways in which varied social groups have participated in those processes over time with a range of motives and diverse outcomes.
- Reflect on their relationship to these processes and their position within these histories.

Requirements and Evaluation:

Reading: Historians know the past mainly through written records, and we can come to sound conclusions in answer to historical questions only by reviewing many and varied records to consider how they illuminate the various dimensions of a given problem or event. That process necessarily involves substantial reading, and reading (and written and verbal communication in conversation with written sources) are the foundational skills of the historical studies.

I have tried to assign reading that is accessible, interesting, affordable, representative, and varied, and no more of it than necessary to give you the evidence you need to understand the history we are here to learn. Reading sources yourself allows you to come to your own conclusions about the past based on your own examination of the historical record without being wholly dependent on your teachers. Try to appreciate the diverse people, places, and perspectives the reading offers you. And remember that careful reading is the basis for your success in all elements of the course.

To allow you to make the most effective use of the reading in course discussions and assessments, you are urged to keep up with the reading material each week. You are also advised to take reading notes so that you can quickly return to the most useful material when you go back to write your essay or study for exams. The recording and organization of useful data is a key professional skill that historical study teaches.

Class Participation: Your participation in the course as measured by consistent, thoughtful, and informed contributions in your discussion sections, supplemented by attendance at lectures and office hours, will account for 10% of your course grade. To foster meaningful discussions across the various elements of the course, students are expected to complete each week's readings before the Wednesday lecture. Your participation should reflect careful engagement with the reading and your own perspective on that reading, as well as respectful dialogue with the ideas of your peers and teachers.

Students who attend all discussion sections and who regularly engage with their peers and instructors in constructive ways, drawing on insights from the readings, can expect to earn an A in class participation. Those who do these things often but not always can expect a B. Those who do these things sporadically can expect a C. Those who regularly skip section, arrive late to section or leave early, or who are clearly unprepared for section will earn a D or lower.

Students who must miss class due to illness or emergency should be in touch with the instructors early and often to discuss how they can keep up with coursework. Students who must be absent for extended period may take part remotely. However, such students should be prepared to provide reasonable documentation about their need for such an accommodation.

Reading Responses: You will write three short essays of no more than two double-spaced pages responding to questions about the readings. These essays serve two purposes. The first is to focus student attention on an important question, problem, or concept from each week's readings, and to prepare students to discuss that question in their weekly discussion sections. The second is to give students regular low-stakes practice in historical thinking and expression consistent with course learning objectives.

Questions will be posted to Canvas by Sunday each week. Essays must be posted to Canvas by Thursday in advance of your weekly discussion section. As these reflections are meant to prepare students for discussion, late submissions will not be accepted or read. To provide students with early feedback, at least one of these essays must be submitted by the third week of the course. The other two may be submitted whenever students choose so long as three are submitted in total by DATE TBD.

Reading response essays will be worth 15% of your course grade. They will be graded on an A/B/C/F basis without pluses and minuses. Those that offer a clear argumentative thesis that answers the question and is supported by a range of relevant evidence from the reading organized in a coherent manner and communicated in clear, well-written prose will earn an A. Those that struggle in one or more of these areas will receive a lower grade. Those who wish to do so may write a fourth response and we will drop their lowest response grade.

Section Quizzes: Each week's discussion section will begin with a brief timed quiz about the assigned reading. The quiz will start when your section starts and end when the last student to arrive on time is finished. Each quiz will be graded on a ten-point scale. Students will earn five points for being present to take the quiz. The remaining five points will be awarded for correct answers to the questions, which will consist of short answer, multiple choice, true/false, and fill-in-the-blank queries. Answers will be reasonably obvious to those who have done the reading.

The purpose of these quizzes is to reward students for attending section ready to discuss the reading. For that reason make-up quizzes will not be allowed or administered except in cases of required absences for sanctioned university events or excused medical absences or documented emergencies. Together the quizzes will be worth 10% of your course grade.

Midterm Exam: A timed, open-note, in-class midterm exam covering reading and lecture material from the first four-weeks of the course will be worth 15% of your course grade. The format will be varied, with multiple choice, true/false, fill-in-the-blank and short answer questions along with interpretive questions that ask you to explain change and continuity over time. Handwritten notes are permitted but computers or computer-generated notes are not allowed without a documented need from AccessibleNU.

Analytic Paper: Students will write a paper of six double-spaced pages due on DATE TBD on how wars and debates about war have played out on Northwestern's campus. Prompts and potential sources will be provided early in the quarter. Papers should make an argument and support that argument with relevant evidence from course readings and independent research presented in an organized way and communicated in clear prose. This work will be worth 30% of your course grade.

Final Exam: A timed, open-note, in-class final exam covering reading and lecture material from the final six-weeks of the course will be worth 20% of your course grade. The question format will be much like that of the midterm exam, but will include more questions covering more material. Handwritten notes are permitted but no computers or computer-generated notes will be allowed without a documented need from AccessibleNU. The exam will be administered on DATE TBD from TIME TBD as appointed by the NU registrar with an alternate but comparable exam option during reading period. Students must plan to sit for one exam.

Grading: Course grades will consist of these elements weighted as follows:

Participation: **10%**	***Midterm:*** **15%**
Reading Responses: **15%**	***Paper:*** **30%**
Quizzes: **10%**	***Final:*** **20%**

Course Policies:

Guiding Principles: The discovery and the dissemination of knowledge that constitute the core purpose of higher education depend upon a collective pursuit of truths that can be demonstrated to fair-minded observers in verbal and written communication through reasoning from empirical evidence. It requires curiosity and an open mind, along with trust, transparency, and seriousness of purpose balanced against a healthy dose of skepticism and critical scrutiny. Striking this balance is difficult, but it is best achieved in engaged, respectful, and diverse communities where we can learn from, test, refine, and relay one another's thinking. The policies spelled out below are intended to foster those values and qualities in respect for our common purpose.

In-Person Learning: Community support and engagement is essential to your success as a student and future professional, and to our collective satisfaction and interest in our work. Your peers are an excellent source of advice, insight, practical and emotional support, and collegiality, now and into the future. For these reasons, I am committed to in-person learning and I expect students to attend lectures and discussions unless health considerations or personal emergencies make that ill-advised or impossible. I consider attendance as part of your participation grade and make recorded lectures available to students only when health or safety considerations require it. Students are not granted permission to attend remotely except as the result of an Americans with Disabilities Act accommodation as determined and documented by AccessibleNU.

Covid Safety: The health and well-being of our community remains our highest priority. Should you test positive for COVID please follow CDC guidelines, which call for isolation until you have been fever-free for at least 24 hours without medications and advise masking for five days beyond that. If you are unable to attend class due to COVID symptoms, please notify course instructors.

Academic Integrity: Students in this course are required to comply with the policies found in the booklet, "Academic Integrity at Northwestern University: A Basic Guide." All papers submitted in this course must be submitted electronically as well as in hard copy, and will be screened for signs of plagiarized or AI-generated content. Cases of suspected academic dishonesty will be reported to the Dean's office. Any student found to have violated academic integrity standards will receive a failing grade for the assignment and may fail the course. For details regarding academic integrity at Northwestern or to download the guide, visit: https://www.northwestern.edu/provost/policies-procedures/academic-integrity/index.html.

Late Assignments: All coursework is due at the date and time specified so that all assignments can be read and evaluated at the same time using a single standard, and to ensure that students receive timely feedback on their work which can be applied in future assignments. Students should make every effort to complete assignments as scheduled. If that proves impossible due to unforeseen reasons beyond your control please notify me or your TA immediately and we will consider an extension. Work submitted late without an extension will be graded down by one letter grade; work more than a week overdue will not be accepted with my permission.

Electronics: Laptops and tablets can be useful to some students for notetaking but can also be distracting to their users and those around them. Students are discouraged from using them in class--lecture notes and slides will be posted to Canvas, making extensive notes unnecessary. If

you feel you must use them in class, please sit in the last rows of the lecture hall and refrain from using them for anything but course-related purposes. *The use of phones and earbuds is strictly prohibited.*

Intellectual Property: All course materials are my intellectual property and not intended for distribution beyond this class. University policy states that "Unauthorized student recording of classroom or other academic activities (including advising sessions or office hours) is prohibited. Unauthorized recording is unethical and may also be a violation of University policy and state law. Students requesting the use of assistive technology as an accommodation should contact AccessibleNU. Unauthorized use of classroom recordings--including distributing or posting them--is also prohibited. Under the University's Copyright Policy, faculty own the copyright to instructional materials--including those resources created specifically for the purposes of instruction, such as syllabi, lectures and lecture notes, and presentations. Students cannot copy, reproduce, display or distribute these materials. Students who engage in unauthorized recording, unauthorized use of a recording or unauthorized distribution of instructional materials will be referred to the appropriate University office for follow-up."

Course Supports:

Content Warning: Lectures, slides, and reading in this course will often include descriptions and depictions of disturbing events and violent acts. I try not to expose students to such material without good reason. When possible, I seek to alert students to when and why I am doing so in advance. That said, war is inherently violent, dehumanizing, and obscene, and we can't understand it without grappling with that fact. If you anticipate difficulty doing so, please come talk to me.

Accommodations: Northwestern is committed to providing an accessible learning environment for all students, and so am I. Should you anticipate or experience disability-related barriers to your success in this course or require accommodation related to a documented disability please speak to the AccessibleNU office (accessiblenu@northwestern.edu; 847-467-5530) as soon as possible. If you have established accommodations with AccessibleNU, please let me know in the first week of the course so that we can work together to implement your disability accommodations. All such discussions will remain confidential.

Religious Observances: Students will not be penalized for class absences to observe religious holidays. If you will observe a religious holiday during a class meeting, scheduled exam, or assignment deadline, please let me know as soon as possible, preferably within the first two week of class. If exams or assignment deadlines on the syllabus fall on religious holidays you observe, please reach out so that we can discuss that coursework.

Well-Being: There are many stresses and strains associated with college and young adulthood. Please seek help if you need it. You can reach out to the following offices directly: www.northwestern.edu/counseling/; www.northwestern.edu/care/; www.northwestern.edu/religious-life/. See also: https://www.northwestern.edu/nuhelp/.

Writing Assistance: The History Writing Center, staffed by a graduate student in history, provides writing support at historywriting@northtwestern.edu and NU's Writing Place is also available in Main Library and at: www.writing.northwestern.edu.

Office Hours: We encourage you to come talk to us about the class concepts and assignments, the history major and/or minor, life in college, post-collegiate plans, or anything else on your mind.

Course Materials: All readings available via Canvas and NU Library reserves

Course Calendar:

Jan 6: Introduction

Jan 8: Violent Beginnings

John Mason Explains the Decision to Burn the Village (2 pp)
Roger Williams on the Limits of Indian Warfare (1 pp)
Thomas Jefferson, Declaration of Independence (2 pp)
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Fred Anderson and Andrew Cayton, *The Dominion of War*, 42-47 (5 pp)
Wayne Lee, *Barbarians and Brothers*, 121-141, 151-159, 171-208 (66 pp)
Barbara Ehrenreich, "Guns and the Democratization of Glory," 175-193 (18 pp)

Jan 13: War in the Early Republic

Jan 15: Jacksonian Violence

Andrew Jackson Proclaims War (3 pp)
Ethan Allen on the Seminole and Mexican Wars (4 pp)
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Daniel Walker Howe, *What Hath God Wrought*, 8-18 (10 pp)
Tom Engelhardt, *The End of Victory Culture*, 16-28 (12 pp)
Gary Gerstle, *Liberty and Coercion*, 17-54 (37 pp)

Jan 20: MLK Day

Jan 22: Civil War

James Henry Gooding Fights for Freedom and Union (3 pp)
Abraham Lincoln, Gettysburg Address (1 p)
William T. Sherman Justifies War Against Civilians (2 pp)
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Wayne Lee, *Barbarians and Brothers*, 232-245 (13 pp)
Drew Gilpin Faust, *This Republic of Suffering*, xi-xviii, 32-60, 266-271 (40 pp)

Jan 27: Warfare Statists

Jan 29: Wars for Empire

William T. Sherman Justifies War Against Indians (2 pp)
Alfred Mahan on Sea Power (2 pp)
Frederick Presher Describes Water Torture (2 pp)
William James on the Moral Equivalent of War (6 pp)
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Barbara Ehrenreich, "An Imagined Bestiary," 194-203 (7 pp)
Robert L. O'Connell, *Sacred Vessels*, 13-27, 60-71 (25 pp)
Fred Anderson and Andrew Cayton, *The Dominion of War*, 317-346 (29 pp)

Feb 3: Great War Origins
Feb 5: Great War Aftershocks

Woodrow Wilson War Message to Congress (3 pp)
Woodrow Wilson and Robert LaFollette on Conscription (4 pp)
Theodore Jones Recounts Combat on Western Front (3 pp)
Northwestern Remembers the First World War (website)
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Fred Anderson and Andrew Cayton, *The Dominion of War*, 346-360 (14 pp)
Bobby Wintermute, "'The Negro Should Not Be Used as a Combat Soldier': Reconfiguring Racial Identity in the United States Army, 1890-1918," 277-298 (22 pp)
George Mosse, *Fallen Soldiers*, 94-106 (12 pp)

Feb 10: Greatest War Frontlines
Feb 12: Greatest War Homefronts

Franklin Roosevelt, Four Freedoms (6 pp)
Peggy Terry on War Work (6 pp)
John Kenneth Galbraith on Bombing (4 pp)
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David Kennedy, *Freedom From Fear*, 615-647 (32 pp)
Gerald F. Linderman, *The World Within War*, 1-47 (47 pp)
Fred Anderson and Andrew Cayton, *The Dominion of War*, 382-395 (13 pp)
Russell F. Weigley, "How Americans Wage War: The Evolution of National Strategy," 2-6 (4 pp)

Feb 17: Cold War
Feb 19: Korean War

Harry S. Truman, Truman Doctrine (4 pp)
Beverly Scott on Desegregation and Combat (4 pp)
William Boldenweck Remembers Inchon Invasion (3 pp)
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Robert M. Neer, *Napalm*, 91-100 (9 pp)
Gerald F. Linderman, *The World Within War*, 319-344 (25 pp)
Fred Anderson and Andrew Cayton, *The Dominion of War*, 395-408 (12 pp)

Feb 24: War Stories
Feb 26: Vietnam Wars

John F. Kennedy, Inaugural Address (2 pp)
John Douglas Marshall on Grandfather and War (2 pp)
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Fred Anderson and Andrew Cayton, *The Dominion of War*, 409-420 (11 pp)
Christian G. Appy, *Working-Class War*, 17-43, 174-205 (56 pp)

March 3: Culture War *(Essay Due)*
March 5: Forever War

Patrick Buchanan, Culture War Speech (5 pp)
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Marilyn Young, "Permanent War," 165-180 (15 pp)
Aaron O'Connell, "Moving Mountains: Cultural Friction in the Afghanistan War," 7-40 (33 pp)

March 10: Reading Period
March 12: Reading Period

Course Staff:
Michael J. Allen
Harris Hall 204, Tues 4-6:00
m-allen1@northwestern.edu
I'm a Northwestern alumnus (PhD 2003, M.A. 1998) and attended college at the University of Chicago (B.A. 1996). Born in northwest Arkansas and raised in rural Kansas, I am first person in my family to graduate college. I taught for five years at North Carolina State University before joining the faculty at Northwestern in 2008. My research and teaching focus on ideas in politics, particularly the ways in which ideas about war, violence, and power shaped and reshaped American political culture. I am currently writing a book titled *The Center Ring: The Making and Breaking of the Liberal Presidency* on the relationship between liberal Democrats and presidential power from World War II through the end of the Vietnam War. My book *Until the Last Man Comes Home: POWs, MIAs, and the Unending Vietnam War* explored how Americans responded to defeat in Vietnam through POW/MIA activism.

I live in Evanston with my wife Julie, who also works at Northwestern, and the youngest of our two children. I enjoy running, hiking and camping, live music, and reading, and I am primary caregiver to four backyard chickens. I love seeing my students perform in the arts and athletics, so please let me know if you are performing or competing and I'll come cheer you on.

Artwork:
The course syllabus and canvas feature *Untitled (Bloodbath #3)*, 2006; the powerpoints feature *Last Day (Red to Black in Six Parts)*, 2013, both by Barnaby Furnas